CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ELECTRICIAN IN THE AI ERA

Can a robot take this job? It can't even crawl into the attic.
No college. Paid from day one. This guide shows the licensed road, step by step.

★ TL;DR — NO COLLEGE. PAID FROM DAY ONE. A LICENSE AI CAN'T HOLD.
THE CATCH: 4–5 YEARS OF APPRENTICESHIP — THE LICENSE IS THE MOAT. ★

FROM THE VIDEO — MASHA'S VERDICT

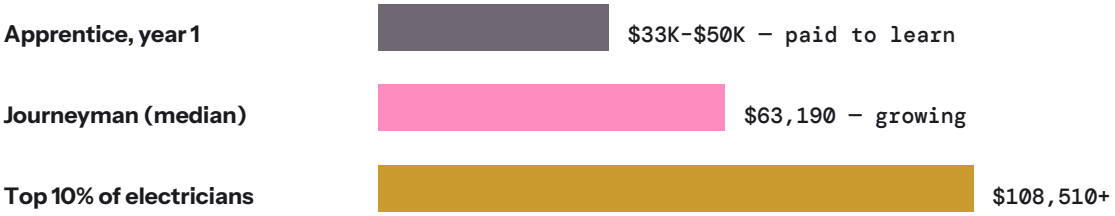
HER VERDICT: YES — "Would I do it? Yes."

HER SCORES · ENTRY 6/10 · MONEY 8/10 · AI RISK 1/10 · OPENINGS 9/10

- No college. A 4–5-year apprenticeship — "they pay you while you learn" — then a state license exam. Start in 2027, fully licensed around 2031.
- AI data centers eat enormous power (her words: one AI server rack pulls ~10× more than a decade ago) — and somebody has to wire them. She cites reports of Texas data-center electricians making up to $280K. Honest check: that is a top-end anecdote — the BLS top 10% nationally is $108,510+.
- "AI can design the data center. AI can write the code. But it can't crawl into a ceiling and fix the wiring."
- Her catch: a data-center build lasts ~2 years, then the crew moves on. Go commercial or industrial instead of betting on the hype.
- Her bet for 2030: "Anything on a screen gets cheap. Hands, chaos, and a license stay human."

Her words from the Career Glitch short — checked against the sources below.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



U.S. government (BLS, May 2025): +9% growth to 2035 and ~72,700 openings every year — mostly retirements, not hype. BLS itself names AI data centers and grid upgrades as demand drivers. Pay swings hard by state: Oregon and Illinois medians sit near $100K, Texas and Florida nearer $58K. See the official numbers

WHAT DOES AN ELECTRICIAN ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ wires buildings — installs the panels, circuits and outlets everything runs on
- ✓ fixes what breaks — including 100-year-old wiring nobody documented
- ✓ makes power legal — work follows the National Electrical Code and passes inspection

Think: the person standing between a building and a fire — with a state license proving it.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Designs layouts and panel schedules. Does load calculations, estimates and code lookups. Makes the paperwork side faster — that part is real.	Crawls the attics and ceilings. Troubleshoots faulty, undocumented wiring on site. Signs the work — a licensed human is legally responsible, and inspectors don't take a robot's word.

⚠ **PREFAB AND MODULAR CONSTRUCTION SHIFTS SOME HOURS INTO FACTORIES, AND CONSTRUCTION MOVES IN CYCLES.**
SERVICE AND REPAIR WORK IS THE STEADY LAYER — BUILDINGS BREAK IN EVERY ECONOMY.

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ hands-on, physical, on-site ✓ paid from day one ✓ different building every week ✓ needed in every town	✗ a desk or remote job ✗ a fast license (4–5 years) ✗ one license for all states — licensing is per state ✗ gentle on the body (heights, shocks, falls — BLS is blunt)

Good fit? You like working with your hands, you're fine with heights and physical work, and you can play a long game for a license that pays for decades.
Bad fit? You want remote desk work, or big money in month one. The money here is real — it is just not fast.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — UNION (IBEW JATC)	DOOR B — NON-UNION (IEC / ABC)
$0 tuition — training is employer-funded. Wages, health insurance and pension from day one. The catch: the most competitive door. Application windows 1–2× a year, aptitude test + interview, ranked waiting lists.	Tuition roughly $2,000–$3,950/year plus books — employers very often pay it. Easier entry; you work full-time for a member contractor while attending class (often one evening a week).

Smart move: apply to both doors, and take a helper/material-handler job while you wait — paid trade experience makes your application stronger.
Where you land after: licensed journeyman → master electrician → supervisor, project manager — or your own contracting business. Industrial and data-center crews sit at the top of the pay range.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP YOUR STATE	APPLY EVERYWHERE	APPRENTICE PAID 4-5 YRS	EXAM JOURNEYMAN	LICENSE $$$ START	MASTER OR OWN BIZ

STEP 1 — Map your state

FREE

- Licensing is per state (a few cities license on their own — Ohio has no statewide journeyman license at all). Find your state electrical board and its exact requirements: BLS — how to become one
- Find the programs covering your ZIP: your local IBEW JATC and the nearest IEC/ABC chapter. Write down their next application window dates — missing a window can cost a year.

STEP 2 — Paperwork and math

FREE

- Gather: diploma or GED, transcripts, driver's license, ID, any military (DD-214) or construction records.
- The aptitude test filters on algebra and reading. Refresh algebra free, 30 min/day: khanacademy.org

STEP 3 — Apply everywhere

FREE

- Submit JATC and IEC/ABC applications as windows open — in parallel, not one at a time.
- Apply to electrical contractors for helper roles at the same time: income now, experience and a reference for the ranked list.

STEP 4 — The apprenticeship

PAID · 4–5 YEARS

- The standard: ~8,000 hours of paid on-the-job training + ~576 hours of classroom (theory, blueprints, code, safety).
- Pay starts around 40–50% of the local journeyman rate and steps up every period toward 100%. Year one typically lands at $16–$25/hour depending on the market.

STEP 5 — The journeyman exam

$150–$350 ALL-IN

- An exam on the National Electrical Code plus your state/local codes. Many are open-book (the NEC) and run by PSI; ~70% is a typical pass mark.
- Real fee examples (application + exam + license): Texas ~ $108 · Massachusetts ~ $330. Confirm current fees with your state board before you pay anything.

STEP 6 — First money — and the ceiling

WHY YOU CAME

- You were paid from day one — the license is what multiplies it: median $63,190, top 10% $108,510+ (BLS).
- After the license: master exam → supervise crews, run projects, or qualify your own contracting business.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today (under 30 min): find your local JATC and IEC chapter; write down the next application windows.
- □ Weeks 1–2: your state board's exact requirements + every deadline in a calendar.
- □ Weeks 3–4: documents assembled; algebra refresh running daily.
- □ Weeks 5–8: applications in everywhere a window is open; helper-job applications in parallel.
- □ Weeks 9–12: aptitude test + interview prep (why this trade, reliability, safety). Wait-listed? Stay in the trade and stay in touch.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ ANYTHING ON A SCREEN GETS CHEAP. HANDS, CHAOS AND A LICENSE STAY HUMAN. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Numbers: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook — Electricians (May 2025). Apprenticeship structure, tuition and apprentice-pay ranges: IEC chapter and JATC program pages; state fee examples from state licensing guides (Texas, Massachusetts, Idaho, Virginia, West Virginia) — fees change and licensing differs by state, always confirm with your state board.